

MALLYA PROVED that behind the cultivated playboy image beats the heart of a businessman



SHEKHAR GHOSH

Vijay Mallya

TAKEOVER TYCOON

He was better known for his flash but in 2007, Vijay Mallya added the cash, showing that his designer trousers came with deep pockets. The self-styled King of Good Times finally proved that behind the carefully cultivated image beat the heart of a canny businessman. Faced with a takeover bid by Kingfisher, Captain G.R. Gopinath of Air Deccan had once said "Mallya is from Venus, I am from Mars", but with the airline industry in the throes of cut-throat competition, the planets finally came together in a Rs 550 crore deal. The buyout made Mallya a major player in the aviation sector overnight. His acquisition spree took on an international flavour when he snapped up Scottish distiller Whyte & Mackay for £595 million (Rs 4,803 crore), allowing him to add—and import—established scotch brands to his portfolio of whiskeys. Mallya continued on the fast track with his takeover of the Anglo-Dutch Spyker F1 racing team for \$123 million (Rs 48 crore), which he promptly renamed Force India. By year end, he was back in his element, cavorting with curvaceous models on the beach while overseeing the shooting of his signature Kingfisher bikini calendar. Entirely fitting, since 2007 was the year Mallya's ambition went naked.

by Dilip Bobb

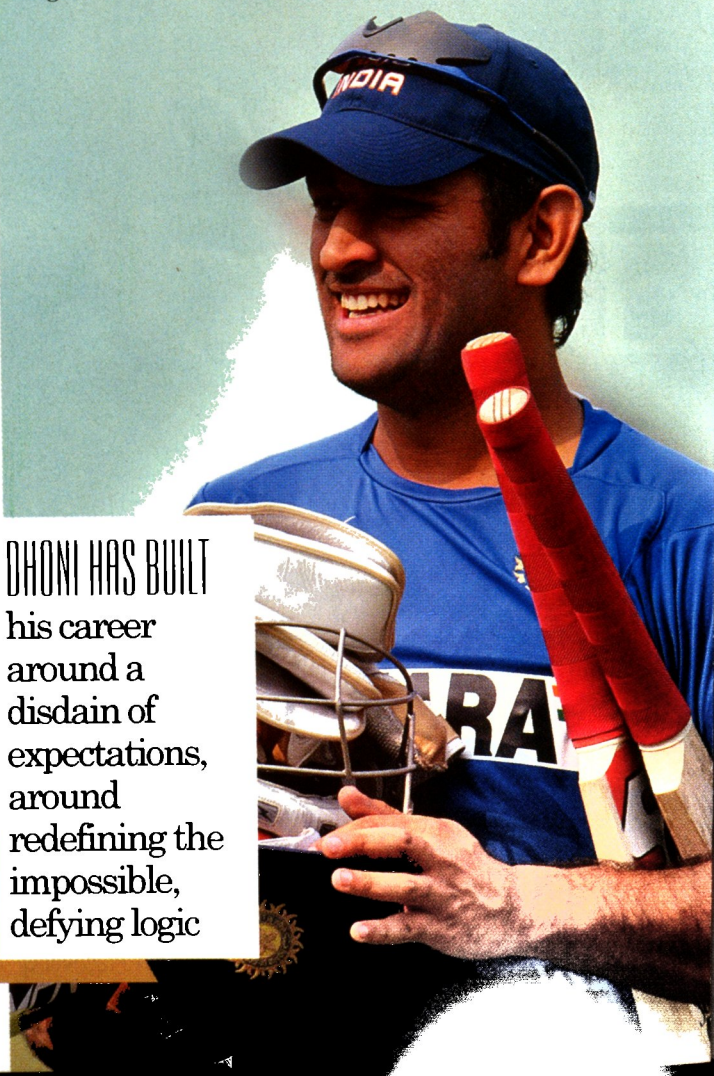
Mahendra Singh Dhoni

DESTINY'S CHILD

This was expected to be M.S. Dhoni's year of sweating profusely. He was expected to consolidate his place in the Test and ODI XIs, not redefine his storm-trooper batting. He was expected to lead some young guys for a hit at some event called the World T20, not to give India its biggest high of the year. He wasn't expected to become ODI captain. Hell, he wasn't even expected to get a hair-cut.

But the man called Mahi has built a career disdainful of expectation. A batsman with a technique not found in any textbook, he has maximised his gifts of power and confidence in 2007 to pull off a series of surprises. A three-hour innings at Lord's helped India earn the draw to set up their first series win in England in 21 years. At the World T20, his no-hoper squad pulled out five win-or-die matches and the title. Pitchforked into India's ODI captaincy right after, he kept his calm, authority and that multi-megawatt smile all through a pressure-packed seven-ODI series vs Australia. India goes Down Under next, where a tough country waits to see this unusual cricketer. It will be his biggest test but few beat against him now because in 2007, Mahendra Singh Dhoni was destiny's child.

by Sharda Ugra



DHONI HAS BUILT his career around a disdain of expectations, around redefining the impossible, defying logic